MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 1 — Unit 2: Poetry

CHAUCER TO THE ELIZABETHAN AGE

Expanded exam notes · Simple explanations + developed discussion

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material (M21EG01DC). These are study aids, not the original textbook. Everyday comparisons are teaching examples. The original notes and full textbook units remain available in the subject folder.

The chapter in one sentence

English poetry developed through storytelling, songs, Chaucer’s portraits of people, Renaissance love poetry, and the surprising arguments of metaphysical poets.

Start with a picture

Think of poetry as a large music collection. Some pieces tell adventures, some repeat a memorable chorus, some describe love, and others make you solve a clever puzzle. This chapter introduces those different kinds of poetry.

Learn it step by step

1. Medieval romance: adventures in verse

A **romance** here is not simply a love story. Medieval romances often involve knights, quests, danger, honour, and marvellous events. A **metrical romance** tells its story in measured verse.

The “matters” are groups of traditional stories:

Group	Main associations
Matter of France	Charlemagne and his warriors
Matter of Rome	Classical heroes and ancient stories
Matter of Britain	Arthur and the knights of the Round Table
Matter of England	English heroes and local traditions

2. Ballads: stories that people can remember

A **ballad** is a narrative song or poem. Traditional ballads often have simple language, dramatic events, dialogue, repetition, and refrains. Oral transmission means versions can change. Imagine a story-song passed from one singer to another rather than a fixed page everyone copies exactly.

3. Chaucer: a storyteller who notices people

Geoffrey Chaucer wrote in Middle English. His work draws on French and Italian writing as well as English experience. His career is often discussed through these influences, but the categories are not rigid boxes.

In *The Canterbury Tales*, a pilgrimage brings together different kinds of people. Their speech, clothing, work, and behaviour help reveal personality and social values. Chaucer makes readers ask whether people practise what they claim to believe.

4. Other medieval voices

John Gower wrote moral and social poetry, including *Confessio Amantis*. **William Langland's Piers Plowman** uses dream vision and allegory to question society and religious life. An allegory gives characters or events a second, symbolic meaning.

English followers of Chaucer include Hoccleve, Lydgate, Hawes, Barclay, and Skelton. Scottish writers include James I, Henryson, Dunbar, and Gavin Douglas. They adapted and developed inherited forms rather than merely copying Chaucer.

5. Wyatt and Surrey: new possibilities for English verse

Thomas Wyatt and Henry Howard, Earl of Surrey, helped adapt the Italian sonnet to English. A **sonnet** is a fourteen-line poem whose patterns help organise thought. Surrey is also important for early English **blank verse**: unrhymed iambic pentameter.

Do not confuse "unrhymed" with "without rhythm." Blank verse has a regular metrical basis even though line endings do not rhyme.

6. Spenser: poetry that builds imaginative worlds

Edmund Spenser's works include *The Shepheardes Calender*, *The Faerie Queene*, and *Amoretti*. He uses pastoral settings, allegory, elaborate form, and moral or national concerns. In an allegory, a knight's journey can also represent a struggle to practise a virtue.

7. Metaphysical poets: thought and feeling together

John Donne, George Herbert, Henry Vaughan, Andrew Marvell, and Richard Crashaw are associated with metaphysical poetry. Their work often uses argument, paradox, and **conceits**: extended, surprising comparisons.

Imagine explaining a close relationship through the two legs of a drawing compass. That unusual image makes an abstract feeling easier to think about. Metaphysical poetry can be religious or concerned with human love; it is not all one subject.

Remember these words

- **Lyric:** a relatively short poem expressing a voice, feeling, or thought.
- **Refrain:** a repeated line or phrase.
- **Pastoral:** writing that uses an idealised rural world.
- **Conceit:** an elaborate, unexpected comparison.
- **Paradox:** an apparent contradiction that invites deeper thought.

Build an exam answer

To discuss poetry’s development, organise the answer by forms and writers. Give one specific contribution for each: ballad—oral storytelling; Chaucer—social characterisation; Wyatt and Surrey—sonnets; Spenser—allegory; Donne—intellectual argument.

Quick check

1. Is every medieval romance a love poem? **No; quests and chivalric adventures are central.**
2. Does blank verse rhyme? **No, but it has metre.**
3. What makes a metaphysical conceit memorable? **It connects apparently unlike things through an extended idea.**

Develop an exam answer

Practice question

Trace the development of English poetry from medieval narrative to metaphysical argument.

Expanded discussion

Medieval poetry drew on both written traditions and oral performance. Metrical romances offered narratives of adventure, loyalty, and chivalric achievement. Their heroic worlds expressed ideals of conduct, although they also delighted audiences through wonder and danger. Ballads used repetition, dialogue, and concentrated action to make stories memorable. The difference between these forms is useful because it shows that poetry served varied audiences and purposes before the Renaissance.

Chaucer enlarged the possibilities of English poetry through narrative skill, characterisation, and the interaction of different voices. In The Canterbury Tales, individual speakers are placed within a shared journey, allowing different occupations and values to come into contact. The significance of the poem is therefore not only that it describes people, but that it creates relationships among social perspectives. His European literary influences also show that English poetry developed through exchange rather than isolation.

The Renaissance introduced further experiments with form. Wyatt and Surrey adapted the sonnet to English, while Spenser brought together allegory, pastoral, and ambitious moral narrative. Metaphysical poets then developed striking combinations of argument and feeling. A Donne conceit does more than decorate an emotion: it helps the speaker reason about love or faith. This history should be described as an expansion of possibilities, not a simple progression in which every new form makes older poetry obsolete.

Suggested answer structure

1. Define the major forms
2. Explain Chaucer’s contribution
3. Discuss Wyatt and Surrey
4. Add Spenser

5. Show thought and feeling in metaphysical poetry

Common mistakes to avoid

Use the correct distinction between blank verse and free verse. Name writers with a contribution, rather than offering names alone.

Turn this into your own answer

Read the question again and choose only relevant sections. Make one clear point per paragraph, explain it, and connect it with a specific textual detail. Add accurate short quotations from the textbook where useful; the discussion above is paraphrase, not quoted text. Adjust length to the marks and time available.

Coverage review: extra exam details

Named examples missing from the earlier summary

The textbook singles out The Nut-Brown Maid and Chevy Chase. The former uses dialogue and a test of fidelity; the latter belongs to a heroic border-ballad tradition involving the Percy and Douglas families. Link examples to narrative concentration, dramatic speech, repetition, and heroic values rather than learning the word “ballad” alone.

For Chaucer’s broader achievement, also revise Troilus and Criseyde and The Book of the Duchess. His engagement with continental models, metrical practice, narrative voices, and Middle English is important beyond the pilgrims. Among Chaucerians, connect Hoccleve with The Regiment of Princes, Lydgate with Troy Book, James I with The King’s Quair, Henryson with The Testament of Cresseid, and Gavin Douglas with his Scots translation of the Aeneid. The older survey’s very harsh evaluation of English Chaucerians is a critical judgement, not a neutral fact.

Forms worth distinguishing

The Petrarchan sonnet commonly uses an octave and sestet, often ABBAABBA followed by a varying sestet. The Shakespearean pattern is ABAB CDCD EFEF GG; the Spenserian pattern is ABAB BCBC CDCD EE. A Spenserian stanza has nine lines, ABABBCBCC, with an alexandrine at the end. Rhyme royal has seven lines, ABABBCC. Surrey’s blank verse is unrhymed iambic pentameter. These are different forms: do not mix the sonnet and stanza patterns.

For metaphysical writers, revise Herbert’s The Temple, Vaughan’s Silex Scintillans, Marvell’s carpe diem argument, and Crashaw’s devotional intensity as examples of variety within the grouping.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit’s assignment prompts, included as a revision checklist, not as predictions of the exam. Longer answers still need evidence from the assigned texts.

1. Discuss the main characteristics of the Age of Chaucer.
2. Discuss Chaucer’s contribution to the development of English poetry.
3. Write an essay on Metaphysical poetry.
4. Discuss the contribution of Wyatt and Surrey to the development of English poetry.

5. What did Spenser contribute to the development of English poetry?